

THE GOOD WEEKEND: Arts and Entertainment

A late developer exorcises his troubled puberty

Writers

By SUSAN HELY

D. M. THOMAS remembers his last visit to Australia neatly. He was 14 and his parents had come to Australia for a two-year stint. "Puberty and Australia arrived on the same day for me," he recalls.

The two events later proved to have a crucial and powerful influence on his life and work.

Thirty-four years later, D. M. Thomas (the initials stand for Donald Michael), the author who soared from obscurity to international fame — or infamy — virtually overnight, with the publication of his difficult and disturbing novel, *The White Hotel*, visited Australia a second time for Writers' Week at the Adelaide Arts Festival.

He caused a bit of fuss at the very start when, after a 36-hour flight, feeling tired and in need of a shower, he discovered the accommodation was "primitive and spartan" with shared bathrooms. When he and the Indian writer Salman Rushdie and the American Russel Hoban complained, there were references in affronted Adelaide newspapers to "whingeing Poms".

IN SYDNEY for three days, he looks very awkward in an opulent 23rd floor York Street apartment, which comes with everything from cookbooks in the kitchen, to birdcages containing three mock birds on the palm, cane-furnished balcony, to bedroom bookcases lined with 50 books ("it's all dead" says Thomas flatly), not to mention the suede walls and the trick mirror walls.

He's also a little weary after a long day of interviews and photographs, readings and launchings of his fourth novel, *Ararat*, and settles himself on the edge of a luxurious cream couch with a couple of packs of cigarettes, which he chainsmokes.

Thomas, with pale, academic looks, sweeping grey hair, crooked teeth and polite manner, seems too reserved to be the writer of vivid, erotic fantasies (some detractors refer to his work as sadism and pornography) and intense horrors, but the subject of sex is never far away.

We chat about the Adelaide Festival, and for him the two highlights were sailing down the river in a boat called Popeye, reading poems against a backdrop of wailing voices from an African choir, and reading to Adelaide schoolchildren a passage from his fifth novel, *The Swallow*, about his fear of tarantulas. (He is still writing the book and expects it to be published in Britain in June and available in Australia later in the year.)

The gasps of horror from the children surprised him. "I thought Australians would not have this phobia, but even they don't like these big spiders." Then almost to himself: "I don't know why this fear of spiders. Some say it's the female genital. They're large and on the outside; they seem to have all body and no mind; so I saw a certain..." His mind wanders off.

Thomas, 48, who took up writing late in life, sees himself as "a late

man, the sort of author who can sell the film rights to *The White Hotel* for \$500,000 and expect Schlöndorff or Bertolucci to direct it.

He revisited Melbourne — his house and his school, University High — to find they no longer existed as they do so powerfully in his memory — "where the true ones still are", he says tapping his head.

He refers to his Melbourne experiences in his poems. They will also play an important part in *The Swallow* (the third book in the *White Hotel* trilogy), which includes a memoir — "a non-fiction within a fiction" — recalling the detail of his two years in Melbourne.

He has only just realised most of his writings are autobiographical. "*The White Hotel* is an autobiography in code, as it were."

"It starts with a voyage to America, which was my parents' honeymoon voyage, and also my adolescent voyage to Australia. The erotic poem full of turbulence,

White Hotel, published in 1981. He claimed he had a feeling he had read it all before. He looked up his copy of Anatoli Kuznetsov's *Babi Yar* and found passages which were virtually identical.

The Guardian reprinted one of them.

It said Kuznetsov wrote: "It started to get dark. Suddenly an open car drew up and in it was a tall, well-built, smartly turned-out officer with a riding crop in his hand... he had a Russian interpreter at his side. 'Who are these?' the officer asked the policemen."

Thomas wrote: "It started to get dark. Suddenly an open car drew up and in it was a tall, well-built, smartly turned-out officer with a riding crop in his hand. At his side was a Russian prisoner. 'Who are these?' the officer asked the policemen..."

But Thomas wearily defends the alleged plagiarism. "Always in my case sources are acknowledged and I think it's rough on the artist and it's something time sorts out."

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There are not many four-letter words, but somehow it strikes people as being highly sexual. I'm concerned with the magic of sex, the greater creative energy it unleashes.

THE ROW flared again six months later when Thomas's translations of Pushkin's selected poems were said to be uncomfortably close to earlier translations.

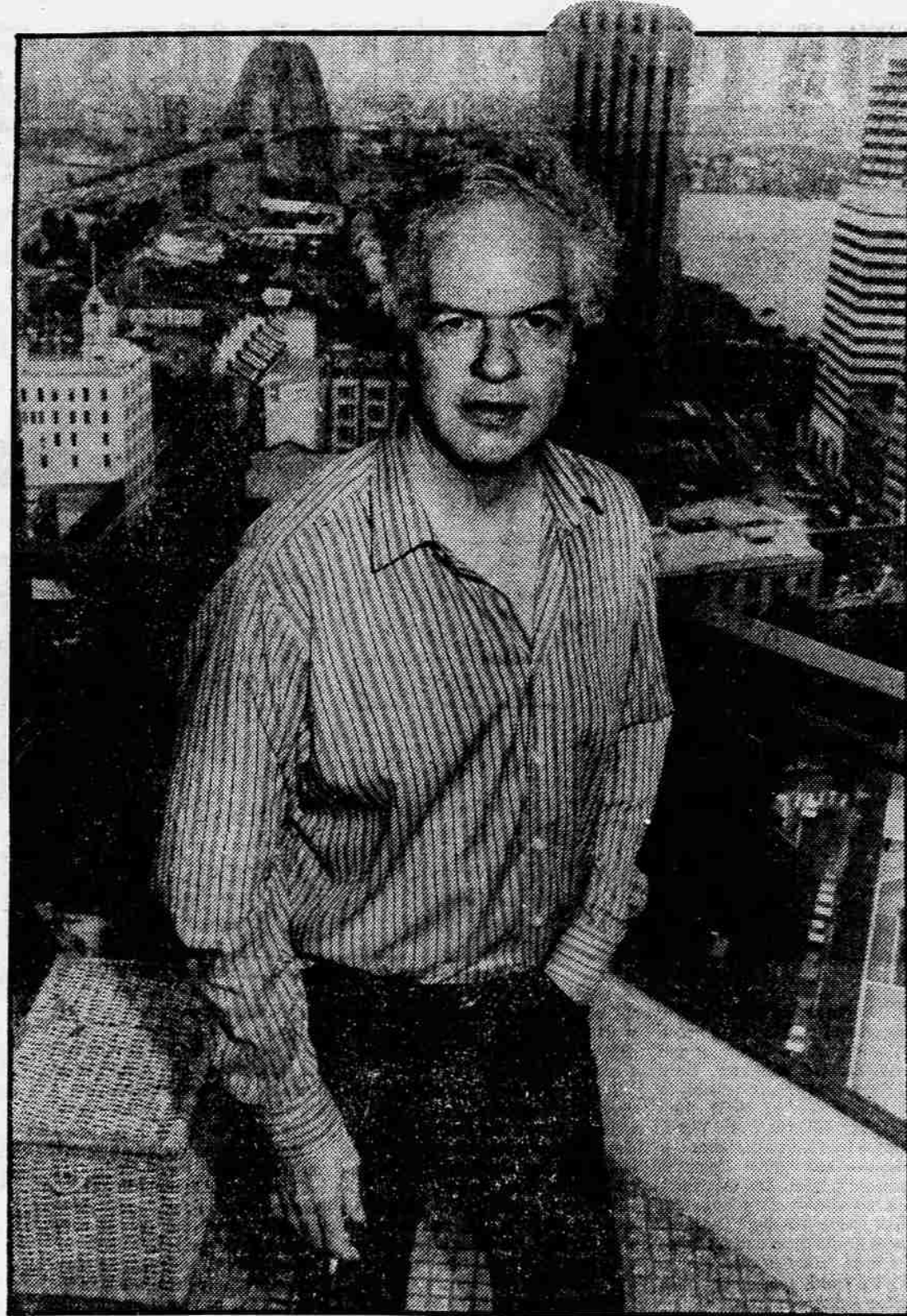
And recently the London Review of Books carried a letter from the author, Christopher J. Walker, who quoted passages from his history of Armenia and juxtaposed them with virtually identical passages from Thomas's *Ararat*.

Thomas maintains he had acknowledged Walker and the passages "are always in the context of history and documents rather than anyone's creative writing — I blend a lot of history with my own writings."

Ararat is similar to his other three novels, which blend the themes of the Holocaust, sexuality and the current state of East-West relations in a style of prose and poetry, fantasy and reality.

Thomas says he treats sex ritualistically, symbolically and poetically and he describes his language as chaste. "There are not many four-letter words, but somehow it strikes people as being highly sexual. I'm concerned with the magic of sex, the greater creative energy it unleashes."

Some critics attack his portrayal of women, calling him a misogynist.



D. M. Thomas on the balcony of his apartment in Sydney.

Thomas, with a hint of annoyance, dismisses it as absolute nonsense.

"The women in my books are far more sympathetic than the male characters. The male character in *Ararat* is much harder than Lisa Erdman in *The White Hotel*. The women in my novels are much nicer people, much better than the men, and this reflects, I suppose, that women are nicer than me. This is far from misogyny and I think the

charge can only be sustained by assuming that I approve of such male characters as Surkov and share their attitudes, which I don't.

"Is it just because I'm a man?" he wonders. "I'm actually much closer to Lisa Erdman, because that's the feminine side of myself."

Showing signs that I'd touched a sensitive spot, he defends himself: "Luckily there are more women who are grateful for the large part

women play in my novels than the more strident ones who object."

And just to get the point across: "I got one letter from a woman who said I wanted Lisa to die because she was over-sexed and a Jewess, but that's crazy. She died because she was at Babi Yar like thousands of other Jews and it's the men who caused it."

One suspects that, unlike Lisa Erdman, it won't rest there.

Mom and apple pie: the punks have gone too far

By KEITH DUNSTAN

ONE OF our top promoters was musing this week. He said the punk band which whipped our audiences into a mood of total frenzy I Spit in Your Gravy.

At the height of their beautiful emotion, they throw Gravox into the audience.

Frankly, as a gravity lover I find this contempt for the true basis of the English diet too much to bear. There are far more savoury groups, such as Apple Pie Motherhood.

These two are the most sacred items in the US — apple pie and mother. Sometimes you come across an American mother who is a little hard to bear, but never a bad American apple pie. This group, unquestionably, would provide moving, succulent, music.

There is also the Peanut Butter Conspiracy. The US has given us some fearful things in the past 208 years, like the electric guitar and the battered hot dog, but peanut butter was always a divine concept and I think I would like the Peanut Butter Conspiracy.

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TO TELL you the truth, I cannot take rock music.

Something very curious happens to human eardrums, usually at an age around 25. In rare cases they survive longer, even as old as 30, but after that no longer can they stand the 200 decibels of sound required to enjoy the full subtlety of rock 'n' roll.

After surviving this devastating loss, there is still one avenue open to enjoyment. There is enormous pleasure to be had in collecting group names. I have a file of 300 or 400 names, many of them provided by the rock expert Paul Stewart.

Some have a delightful euphony, some have a gifted offensiveness, some are designed to shock into

The Prunes are a sweet lot. Their star act is to dissect a dead pig on stage.

Friends as torchbearers: von Trotta pulls aside the veil again

Film

Labour Of Love (M)
Valhalla Cinema, Glebe
Cross Creek (NR)
Lyceum Cinema, Pitt Street

By ANNA MARIA DELL'OSO

MATES, pals and buddies are open and well-documented relationships in literature and cinema, while friendships between women have tended to be depicted as mysterious.

The tendency is to defensively reduce them in some way. Either there is an explicitly sexual overtone to the relationship, an implied emotional immaturity and dependency, or the women are prised apart by the introduction of jeal-

ousy and bitchery, usually over a male.

Either way, the bonding between women lies hidden under a veil which exerts a disturbing fascination. As an insecure husband in Von Trotta's *Labour Of Love* says exasperatedly to his wife: "What do you two have to talk about all day?"

Ruth (Angela Winkler) and Olga (Hanna Schygulla) simply recognise each other. Though they seem utter opposites, with Ruth introverted and excruciatingly sensitive and Olga competent, world-wise and practical, the women instinctively sense they are expressions of the same struggle.

Margarete Von Trotta has long been fascinated by the interactions of women, not so much in groups or as a subterranean other network to the masculine world, but in their strange pairs and doubles, the female best friends and sisters relationships.

She continually returns to a

a light-and-dark pattern where one woman is strong, competent, ego-directed and apparently mastering the problems of contemporary life, while the other is usually moody, dark, neurotic, rebellious and a painful misfit, unable to avoid a violent confrontation with her environment.

Labour Of Love displays the characteristic Von Trotta intelligence and cohesion, her uncanny talent for isolating the intellectual mannerisms and political defences of a generation who have reached their mid-thirties in the 1980s. It is a sure, personal film, simpler than her *Dark Times*, with a moving profundity of insight and many intensely beautiful images.

Von Trotta's usual care in the characterisation of male characters, however, seems weakened in *Labour Of Love*. The men are bloodlessly unconvincing even in their most well-scripted insensitivities; they are pale with the effort of

representing only the collective catch-phrases of oppression rather than the fully-fleshed complexities of their particular blind, fearful and counter-dependent lives. More than any other of Von Trotta's films, *Labour Of Love* teeters dangerously on the brink of self-pity and the bewailing of women as victims. Von Trotta's delicately developed idea of friends as torchbearers, waiting at the crossroads, escorting each other from regression, death and darkness, is a joy, however, as is the subtle, multi-faceted relationship between the film's two principal women characters.

The popular, mobile Hanna Schygulla is all easy-groomed confidence as Olga, a lecturer in nineteenth-century German literature who is separated from her theatre-director husband. Olga is living in warm happiness with a pianist, Alexei (Vladimir Yordanoff), and her son, Christof (Felix Moeller). She meets Ruth, a dark-

haired, introverted artist, one summer at a friend's winery, saving her from a suicide attempt. Ruth's husband, Franz (Peter Striebeck), is an academic colleague of Olga's, specialising in the politics of nuclear disarmament and world affairs.

Franz initially encourages Olga's friendship with his delicate and usually withdrawn wife, but it is soon clear that he is uneasy at any possibility of change in his wife's neurotic dependencies and fears.

Though Von Trotta is overly earnest, Germanic and thorough in her portrait of the destructiveness before growth, with not a single relationship or marriage allowed to succeed or point to any hope of unity between masculine and feminine, *Labour Of Love* is a powerful, intelligent, beautifully realised film, enormously revealing of the mutual recognition, healing and tending aspect of women's friendships.

MARY Steenburgen's mobile, dark-framed face and her glove-fitting sympathetic abilities as an actress are the finest features of *Cross Creek*, apart from the lush photography of backwoods Florida, with its hot, verdant, water-dappled lushness.

Undoubtedly heart-warming, *Cross Creek* is a high-rent version of the Walt Disney backwoods sagas of the 1960s, complete with a fawn and an adolescent fearful of maturity. *Cross Creek* is so damn meaningful, so redolent of the spirit of human endeavour and the oneness of the earth, it may make more urban-scarred and rat-faced city film cynics puke. Depending on one's ability to be entranced by story-telling, no matter how naive, *Cross Creek* holds many entertaining rewards while ending up a not particularly memorable movie. It is inspirational, with a pleasing symmetry of struggle and happy ending. It gives one a cosy feeling. And

colourful characters with weird backwoods American accents are always fun.

Mary Steenburgen plays the stubborn, slightly frozen Marjorie McKinnon Rawlings, an aspiring writer with a massive writer's block that seems to stem from an alienation from experience itself. Leaving her husband and her New York journalist's life, Rawlings moves to an orange grove in Florida. *Cross Creek* is utterly isolated, desperately poor and the grove and homestead in ruins.

Although it is difficult to believe in Marjorie Rawlings's tough struggle against the elements when she has so many black servants and farm labourers willing to tend the homestead and orange grove for nothing but their keep, *Cross Creek* is nevertheless an engrossing story, a sweet Hollywood movie with many excellent character performances and skilled photography.

apoplexy, many are pornographic, but lots are wonderfully funny, worthy even of Spike Milligan.

For example, I love the sound of Nathan Ashbire and the Pingrove Boys. I am sure you would go to hear Alberto Y Los Trios Paranois. There is a beautiful, whimsical quality about Mars Needs Women, and the political message behind The Entire Production Line of British Leyland is irresistible.

Then there is the awesome heavy metal with the awesome names designed to inspire terror: The Corpse Grinders... The Crushed Buzzards... The Painters and Dockers... Perhaps they could follow up with a new group titled The Costigan Report.

Or would you rather the charms of the Charles Manson Swing Quartet? We won't go into the attractive, psychotic twisted history of Mr Manson, but Paul Stewart reports they provide porno movies plus music in the background pouring through a speaker.

Let's see. There's The Athol Guys. They all dress up in dark glasses and beards as Athol Guy look-a-likes. There's a Flock of Emus. Presumably they gallop all over the stage and jerk their heads a lot.

Justified Raddish. Touch of class here. They appear dressed up as fruit and vegetables then throw them out into the audience. Dean and the Martians. As a play on Dean Martin it would suggest they are a boozy, sleepy-eyed group.

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OH, YOU can pick the English Cops, Kissing the Pink, the Buzzcocks, Doctor Feelgood, The Slits, and The Virgin Prunes. The Prunes are a sweet lot. Their star act is to dissect a dead pig on stage.

What else? Well, there's Chocolate Watchband, Tone Deaf and the Idiots, Hee Bee Gee Bees, Fingerprints, Little Bee Bitch, The Ooble Dooble Band and Pure Food and Drug Act, or for the true enthusiast Iggy Pop and the Stooges.

Paul Stewart says Iggy is the wildest guy in rock. He dives headlong into the audience, hangs upside down from the rafters and cuts himself with razor blades. One wonders what this does for the technical brilliance of the music.

Pantries. We don't know what sort of actions Pantries take, nor the styles of Phlorescent Leech and Eddie, the Pigsty Light Orchestra, Parrafin Jack Flass Ltd or Rainbow Red Oxidiser, but they sound great.

Pavlov's Dog is an interesting one. You will remember Pavlov trained his dogs to do extraordinary complex actions by constant repetition. Maybe all groups and orchestras eventually turn into Pavlovian dogs.

A great show avoids TV's short grabs

Art

By TERENCE MALOON

JOHN Dunkley-Smith's installation at Artspace in Surry Hills is an exception which proves a rule. The rule is that the larger part of current art is profoundly, and often unconsciously, affected by television. TV's mode of "short grabs" has become common currency in the visual arts, and mass-media cliché have even come to connote "reality".

Dunkley-Smith's work, on the other hand, luxuriates in slowness and takes something very unprepossessing as its point of departure. A sequence of 81 colour slides is projected in silence in the empty, almost dark gallery. The large images on the wall show us the same room we're standing in, but with the windows and doors, rather than the slide projector, as the source of light. In effect, the projected images usurp the reality of the darkened room.

The sequence of slides unfolds according to a procedural method. Moving his camera around a chalk circle on the floor, Dunkley-Smith could either increase or decrease the complexity of each slide. Starting from a single exposure, he accumulated up to 11 exposures on a single slide. There are only four "straight" shots in the entire sequence. By multiplying the exposures, the projected image becomes ever more immaterial and "filmy". It also increases the amount of light on the wall. The light rebounds into the

room, so that real space regains its priority over fictional space in our perception.

But the installation is more than just a charming conundrum about the relation between art and reality. And if, on the face of it, there is nothing especially interesting about Dunkley-Smith's working method, it results in some amazingly beautiful images. The sequence is a cycle without beginning or end, dematerialising and re-materialising the walls, chairs, ladder, posters of Chairman Mao and Chou Enlai, 1984 calendar and other features of

the baffling spatial complexity of Al Held's recent paintings, Richard Estes's reflections in shop windows, 1960s stripe-paintings etc. But spotting these references is a small, incidental enjoyment in a fascinatingly rich and well-rounded aesthetic experience.

Dunkley-Smith's achievement is to show us the space in which we stand, to transfigure this into an artistic event, and to make us rapt spectators of something we would not normally give a second glance.

Dunkley-Smith's achievement is to... make us rapt spectators of something we would not normally give a second glance.

Artspace's workaday geography. The slides successively admit and then banish what seems like an outpouring of heavenly light.

A pillar in the gallery interrupts the beam from the slide projector and masks out a dark vertical on the wall. This becomes part of the fiction of the slide, like a real object in the photograph. When the slide is most over-exposed, and comes to resemble a light-drenched net curtain, the dark shadow appears to be the only substance in a milieu that is a shadow-of-a-shadow-of-a-shadow.

Allusions to other works of art filter in, whether by accident or design — the vertical divisions in Barnett Newman's abstract paintings, Matisse's famous Red Studio,

THE theorists of post-modernism stress the use of quotation and parody as one of the defining features of post-modern art. The post-modern, it seems, is now so inclusive a category that Peter Blayney's paintings at Robin Gibson's, Robert Rooney at Roslyn Oxley's, Herbert Flugelman at the Macquarie Galleries, and Nicholas Hamper at Rex Irwin's could all be considered part of the same phenomenon.

Wary of the click-click titillations, the in-jokiness and "short grabs", and stupefied by all the cliché (whether it's intended as a parody or not, a cliché is a cliché), I tend to warm to work that is not just about these predictable

Dominated by the mass-media as we are, it is easy to understand how post-modernists can contend that we're encircled by a universe of second-hand images which we'll go on repeating ad nauseam. Academic artists (or pre-modernists) have held very similar beliefs in the past. Remember the impressionist painters' symbolic protest in the academic artists' holy of holies a century ago?

The impressionists, like most other painters in Paris at that time, used to go to paint in the Louvre. But unlike their academic counterparts, they didn't copy the Old Master paintings in the gallery; they painted scenes out of the windows.

Nicholas Hamper at Rex Irwin's Gallery juggles quotations and stylistic parodies more cleverly than most people (his paintings have something of early David Hockney's cheeky self-assurance). On one level, you could say that his paintings were art-about-art, and were engrossed in their own mongrelised style (a mixture of Parisian and English modernism circa 1920, plus a lurid palette very much of this moment). But on another level, you could say that his paintings were about Sydney and about his experiences as a newcomer to Australia.

Perceptive, witty, perverse, and a far cry from the tourist-cliche of native Australian painters churned out by the thousands, we can re-discover aspects of the city and see them afresh through a stranger's eyes.

One of Hamper's paintings is actually a view of the wharves at Woolloomooloo, seen from a window of the Art Gallery of NSW.

GREECE AND ROME

TWO illustrated Saturday Seminars with DR IAN GUTHRIE at the Forum Centre (35 Clarence St).

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ART AUCTION

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Under instructions from the Spastic Centre of N.S.W. in the matter of the Estate of the late Sir Roland Wakelin. The Estate of the late Sir Eric Langier, several corporate clients and other vendors.

The important offering will include a major oil painting "Pearl Fisherman at Broome" by Sir Russell Drysdale. Other contemporary paintings include works by Arthur Boyd, Sir Sidney Nolan, Fred Williams, Charles Blackman, David Boyd, Gilroy Pugh, Hugh Sawrey and numerous other major Australian artists. A major selection of 40 paintings by IOLAND WAKELIN. These works are being sold for the Spastic Centre of N.S.W. from the Estate of Mrs Wakelin.

The collection of quality traditional works include an early Harbour scene by Lloyd Rees, 2 important oils by Elsie Greer, 2 water colours by Sir Hans Heynen, and other paintings by Albert Namatjira, James R. Jackson, George Lawrence, Norman Lindsay and Rubery Bennett and a rare woodcut by Margaret Preston.

IMPORTANT LATE ENTRIES: 1989 Heidelberg Street, Beach scene by Elsie Greer, Early Rubery Bennett, Large Narabeen Sydney Long, J. J. R. Jacksons and Robert Johnson.

VIEWING: At Menzies Hotel, Sunday 18, 11 a.m. to 8 p.m. Monday 19, 11 a.m. to 9 p.m.

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